

It is a scheme developed by the department to provide for the employment of Australian Government Authorised Officers (AAOs) by independent employment providers. Under the Scheme, agencies will supply AAOs to Australian export slaughter establishments to meet EU standards.

Many countries accept product prepared to the Australian Standards, however where there are additional requirements, the department will develop programs to facilitate trade to those markets.

The European Union requires that post-mortem inspections are performed by inspectors employed by a party other than the food business operation. Therefore to export product to that market, AAOs must be sourced from an Independent Employer.

AAOs can be employed by an export registered abattoir or labour hire provider (e.g. independent AAO employer).

For the EU market, AAOs must be employed by an independent AAO employer approved by the department to supply AAOs.

EU-listed establishments must use AAOs employed by an accredited independent AAO employer for EU production runs. The establishment should ensure that the employer they choose has met and continues to meet the criteria of the Independent Employer of AAOs Accreditation Scheme.

The establishment's approved arrangement must identify that AAOs are sourced from an accredited independent employer for EU production runs. If an amendment to the approved arrangement is required to meet this requirement, the establishment must make an EX26b application to approve the amendment as a significant amendment.

The department will only supply Food Safety Meat Assessors (FSMAs) to perform post-mortem inspection where it is necessary to meet importing country requirements.

Yes. Where establishment management elect to use AAOs during a shift to conduct inspection, the management may choose to employ AAOs through independent AAO employers for specific runs and revert to company AAOs for other runs.

No. An AAO must be paid by the Independent AAO Employer at all times for whatever work they do at a meat establishment and cannot at any time work directly for or be paid by the meat establishment.

Yes. These establishments will need to amend their approved arrangement to reflect these arrangements.

An abattoir can use relief AAOs hired by the Independent AAO Employer to conduct other activities provided:

- the AAO is not nominated in a position of management and control of the establishment; and
- the primary function of the AAO is to perform meat inspection activities.

Where this may not be achievable, the owner or operator may make an application for consideration by the department, along with proposed amendments to the company's Approved Arrangement to ensure

that there are no conflicts of interest or pecuniary interests, real or perceived, identified with the activities and responsibilities of AAO.

AAOs can be utilised to perform additional activities that are reasonably considered to be associated with meat inspection skills. Activities such as butchering or labouring are outside the scope of these associated activities and therefore would not be acceptable tasks to be performed by an AAO.

Information on the application process for AAOs, including the application form and the Independent Employer of AAOs Accreditation Scheme is available [on the department's website](#).

To participate in this initiative visit the [Independent Employer of AAOs Accreditation Scheme](#) and download the Scheme information.

Departmental Contacts: AAO Coordinator, Meat Export Branch.

Email: aao@aff.gov.au

Telephone: 02 6272 3933

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/export/controlled-goods/meat/elmer-3/independent-employer-of-aaos-accreditation-scheme/abattoir-owners-operators-fact-sheet>